might be like if I could score the winner; rather that thought in my mind than the opposite: *If something were to go wrong tonight, Victoria, I don't know if I'd be able to go through all the stuff that happened last time again.*

Then, just as we were getting ready to say goodbye, she gave a little chuckle:

'Now don't do anything stupid, will you?'

I laughed and the tension lifted.

'I don't know. I'll see how it goes. Maybe I should just go out and kick one of them for old times' sake.'

I'll never forget the passion, the sense of purpose, in our dressing room before we went out to face Argentina. I looked at Michael Owen: he had this aura about him, pure undiluted concentration on the job in hand. I looked at Rio Ferdinand, at Sol Campbell: their faces had those same calm, fixed expressions; the same intensity burning away behind their eyes. *This is it. How can we not win this tonight? Come on, England.*

I'd never heard us like this before. The noise was echoing in the tunnel while we lined up with Argentina; English voices—the players' voices—shouting, growling, urging one another on, as if we were going into battle. And, from the start, a battle is what it was. Gabriel Batistuta's tackle on Ashley Cole about a minute into the game was horrible. Later in the game and he'd have been sent off. It was a chance for a big player to put his mark on the game. We'd talked beforehand amongst ourselves about not showing Argentina anything in the way of respect. We could be sure they wouldn't be showing us any. That lunge from Batistuta said it all, from their point of view. But it broke a spell: it shocked everyone in the stadium, players and fans. Never mind Sweden. Never mind four years ago. Never mind Beckham's foot. This was the challenge: were we strong enough to face it? The atmosphere inside the Dome was electric. Every England supporter could sense it, I'm sure: every one of our players seemed to rise to the occasion at that instant. *Face it? We'll do better than that.*

It took me longer to settle into the game than my team-mates. By the time my foot had warmed up enough to stop giving me twinges of pain, we were already playing really well, a different team to the one that had struggled less than a week ago. We were first to the 50–50 balls, Nicky Butt was all over the field, getting his foot in, nudging us forward. Even at 0–0, it already felt like our night. Owen Hargreaves got injured early on and Trevor Sinclair came on